

DEADLY STRIKE Kashmiri Pandits at a protest in Budgam after the Rahul Bhat killing

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KASHMIR

PEACE MAKES AN EXODUS

By Moazum Mohammad in Srinagar

On May 12, Rahul Bhat, a revenue department clerk, was shot down inside his office in Budgam's Chadoora area. That inaugurated a season of 'targeted attacks' in the Valley—such a perceptible step away from the ordinary run of militant violence that New Delhi's Kashmir policy again became the topic of debate. The past few weeks saw three more killings—of teacher Rajni Bala from Samba, Jammu; bank manager Vijay Beniwal from Hanumangarh, Rajasthan; and Dilkhush, a brick kiln worker from Bihar. The pattern of targeting was clear: Kashmiri Pandits, civic officials, migrant workers, cops. Nineteen people have fallen to the gun till date in 2022. By June, visuals of a mini-exodus were all over.

Pandit families who relocated to the Valley have had enough—it's been nine months of living in dread, ever since three Hindus and a Sikh woman were killed in October. Ashwani, one of some 6,000 working in Kashmir under the PM's Development Package (PMDP), stays in Budgam's high-security Sheikhpora camp but, like all his cohorts, he's adamant on getting a transfer to Jammu or anywhere else. "Our only demand is relocation...we are not safe here," he says. They have been staging daily sit-ins at the camps since May.

So far, the administration led by Lt Governor Manoj Sinha has posted 177 teachers to safe zones in Srinagar, but the circulation of orders on social media along with phone numbers has further angered the staff. Relocation outside Kashmir, says a senior official, is out of the question for two reasons—the PMDP job contract is non-transferable and, second, the Centre does not want to see another mass exodus of Hindus. If events echo what happened in the early 1990s even on a smaller scale, the optics would not be very flattering for the Centre. But between perceptions and reality, the Pandits naturally choose the latter.

The Kashmiri Pandit Sangharsh Samiti has submitted a four-page letter to Chief Justice Pankaj Mithal of the J&K High Court seeking direction to the Centre to allow religious minorities to leave the Valley. Police and paramilitary forces have prevented Pandits from moving out of the transit accommodations, causing commotion on several occasions. "We are being used," says Pandit representative Sunny Raina. "*Woh humein bali ka bakra bana rahe hain* (They are making sacrificial lambs of us). They just want to show the world that the Pandits are braving the militants and staying on."

Since Article 370 was turned into a dead letter and the erstwhile state bifurcated into Union territories in August 2019, New Delhi had been showcasing its achievements in Kashmir: reduced terror attacks, a barrage of encounters that has left militant outfits thin on both leadership and cadre, and the rehabilitation of Pandits. This year, when Kashmir is hosting over 6,000 tourists daily, should have been a time marked by hope of peace.

Instead, the militants changed tack, in a spree of attacks on soft targets. The security apparatus is overstretched—it's already shouldering the burden of having to secure